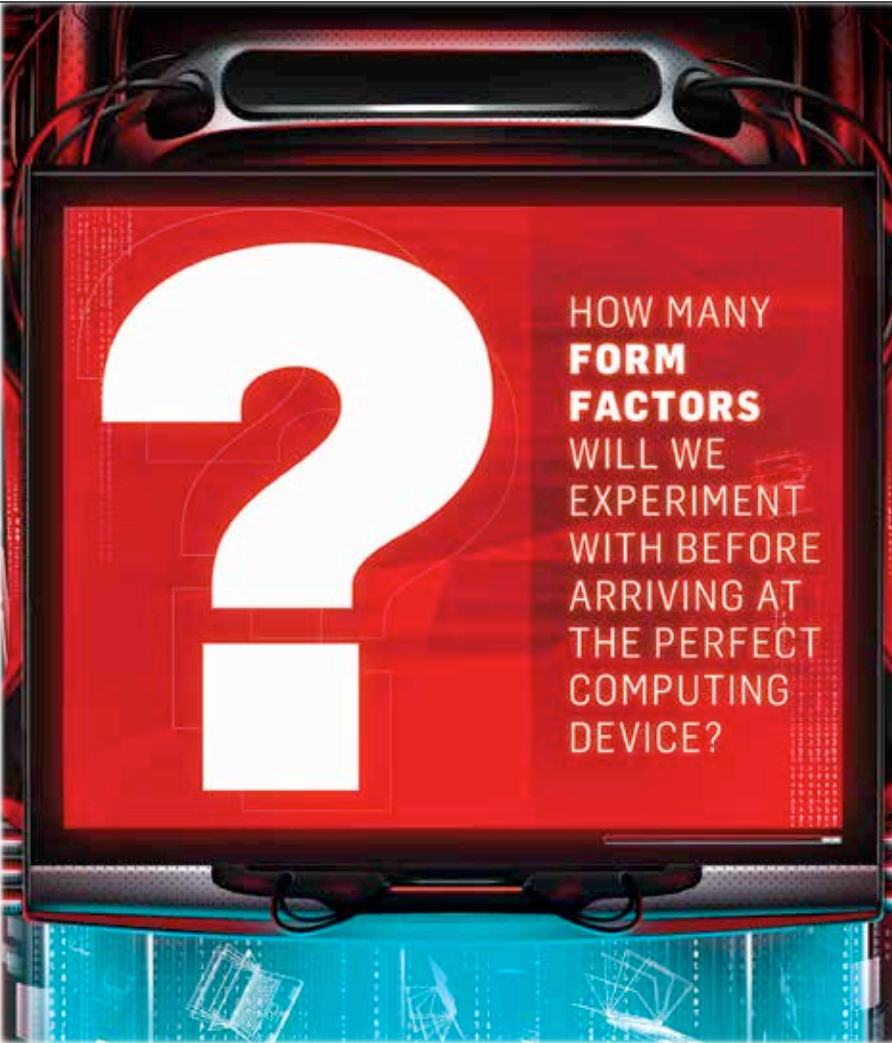




U + I = WHEE!

The UI game needs to change. It shouldn't be about making icons look prettier, it should do away with them once and for all and end their 30+ year reign

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Let's face facts, we've been saying this for some time now, but a big change is needed in computing, and everyone knows it. We're at a crossroads of sorts, because finally ideas and prototypes of actually new computing devices are appearing and being talked about. Some actually seem like viable options, or a step in the right direction even, while others just appear to be throwing some permutations and combinations of form factors together to find a way forward in a hit-and-miss manner.

Everyone went crazy with touch thanks to Apple bringing touch into the main-

stream, and yes, it's earned them a lot of money, and cost us consumers an arm and a leg to get the latest and greatest releases. However, over the past year or two, things are getting crazier.

A lot of us own phones that cost us more than our laptops, and yet we keep running back to the good old laptop to do anything of use. It's the wife and mistress analogy from old Bollywood days – the mistress was hot, looked good on your arm, cost you a lot to keep, but she was never able to give you the love and satisfaction that your faithful wife could. A clichéd moral, sure, but it's probably more factual in the PC/Phone conundrum than the wife/mistress one.

If you're a student, have you tried writing out submissions or doing research only

on your phone? If you're working, have you created a presentation, done some deep research into any topic using only your tablet or phone? Of course, there are many who do this, because they choose to not have a laptop or desktop, and only live on a tablet or phone, but even they cannot truthfully say they haven't missed the trusty computing devices of yore at least a couple of times a day.

I can't get no...

As the popular Rolling Stones song goes, there just isn't any one device out there that gives you total satisfaction. Way back in 2005 we talked about convergence in an anniversary issue, and what it promised. We're still waiting... Yes, almost everything has converged into a single device that you keep in your pocket, but there are still a few critical things that need to be added to the mix.

Back in the old days, we also foresaw that we consumers would go from being gullible walking wallets to prosumers. We have become exactly that. Look at the simple change in yourself: what used to be a simple buying choice earlier (ask a few friends, listen to a salesman and pick one), has become akin to doing enough research to be able to write a thesis on the subject. We compare the minute details, ask a thousand questions, and even while making the payment for the product we've chosen, have a tiny voice in our heads screaming "Wait for something better!" or "Are you sure this is the best?"

Yes, we all enjoy the post purchase endorphin rush that tells us our device is better than anyone else's "for my needs", but deep down, we all know something's missing.

So what are the problems?

A lot of the problems we face today are really no different from a decade ago. We all want computing devices to be insanely fast, able to do everything we demand of them, and yet we want them with us 31.5 million seconds a year, want batteries to last a day (or more) and also expect them to be affordable. Deep down, we're all greedy toddlers with insatiable appetites, crawling around touching everything and screaming "I want..." Not that there's anything wrong with that; because at Digit we're the brattiest and fattest little bunch of technology babies you'll ever meet.